been approved—this was an enormous sum in those days, and one that Israel needed like air to breathe. These factors, together with Kollek's warning, led to Israel's proposal during the second round of the Lausanne Conference to absorb 100,000 refugees. The proposal was rejected outright by all of the Arab states, which continued to insist that Israel absorb all of the refugees.

Two other initiatives that arose during the suspension of the Lausanne Conference—and both ended in failure—should be mentioned parenthetically. One initiative was talks between Israel and King Abdullah of Jordan regarding a separate bilateral peace agreement, with Jordan gaining control of the West Bank. The second was the idea of handing over the Gaza Strip—with its 150,000 residents and 250,000 refugees—to Israel, and for this to be considered Israel's contribution to the solution of the refugee problem as well as a way to help open the door for negotiations for final peace agreements with the Arab states. This plan grew more and more complicated as Britain, with quite a bit of American support, introduced all kinds of imperial considerations, such as territorial exchanges. Israel was not enthusiastic about the idea but for diplomatic reasons decided not to reject it. This time, too, the Arabs did the Israelis' work for them—the Egyptian government opposed the idea, and it was dropped.

The government of Israel was subject to heavy pressure throughout the deliberations of the Lausanne Conference, first of all by the bloc of Arab states, which took an all-or-nothing stance, insisting that Israel absorb all the refugees into its territory and that otherwise there would be no progress toward peace agreements. The position of the United Nations was presented as neutral, but in practice it adopted an anti-Israel stance from the outset of the process. The person who shaped this position was Count Bernadotte, who was guided by a set of considerations that he regarded as moral but that lacked even an iota of pragmatism. He placed demands on Israel of the sort that one did not need to be a great genius to understand that no Israeli government could ever accept.

The US administration, from its official representative Ethridge to Secretary of State Acheson to President Truman, believed in the principle of a compromise by which the two sides should be partners in solving the refugee problem. But the American demands of Israel— that it absorb about a quarter of a million refugees—far exceeded the absorption capacity of the Israeli government.